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Not just stoves: Gas leaks in homes may be widespread

Study points to elevated levels of methane

By Kate Selig
GLOBE STAFF

You've heard that gas stoves pose a health risk. But new research indicates that the threat may extend to your whole gas system.

A Boston University study found that low levels of natural gas may be seeping into many New England homes with gas heat. The gas contains pollutants including benzene, a known carcinogen, raising concerns that residents are breathing in small quantities of toxins around the clock.

"There's no lower limit to what's considered to be safe for some of those

compounds," said Nathan Phillips, a Boston University physiological ecologist and the study's lead author.

Experts cautioned that more research is needed to establish whether these leaks jeopardize human health. Homeowners can look for leaks and plug them up, though some are difficult to address.

Phillips said the paper, published in May, provides one more reason for the state to consider transitioning off natural gas altogether. The study was funded by ZeroCarbonMA, a climate advocacy group based in Brookline, and

NATURAL GAS, Page A8

Mass. public defense system broken, inspector general says

Calls it expensive and inefficient

By Lea Skene
GLOBE STAFF

The state's inspector general is coming down hard on the public defense system in Massachusetts, which provides legal representation to poor people, calling it highly expensive, inefficient, and lacking proper oversight.

The Office of the Inspector General has found several problems with the current structure, which came under intense scrutiny last year during a

months-long work stoppage by lawyers demanding higher pay. The collective protest threw the state's busiest courts into crisis as more than 1,000 cases were dismissed and some defendants were released because they didn't have access to counsel.

The scathing report, which was released Wednesday, addressed the state's public defense system as a whole, which includes both government-employed public defenders and private attorneys paid by the state, or bar advocates.

While that work stoppage brought certain issues to the forefront, there

are significant underlying flaws that require more attention, the report found.

State Inspector General Jeffrey S. Shapiro in a statement called the system broken and heaped blame on the state's public defender agency, the Committee for Public Counsel Services. He listed three main problems: the process for determining who qualifies for indigent defense, the caseload among public defenders, and the fee structure for bar advocates.

Those "must be addressed so the Commonwealth can sustainably pro-

PUBLIC DEFENDERS, Page A9

Enough work, time to play

By Chris Serres and Michael Silverman
GLOBE STAFF

After a brief outage a few weeks ago, the official FIFA countdown clock outside Faneuil Hall Marketplace is working again, ticking off the hours and minutes to the start of what has been, for Boston, a less-than-smooth walkup to the world's biggest sporting event.

Now it's finally game time, the moment when consternation gives way to celebra-

Boston had some tough lessons to learn as it prepared for the World Cup

tion as the first matches get underway Thursday in Mexico, and the first in Massachusetts on Saturday. With the hard part of the planning mostly behind, experts in planning, marketing, and tourism took stock of the Boston preparations with an eye on what the region can learn.

"The lesson from Boston's experience is to prepare soon, soon, and even sooner," said Rob Prazmark, founder and chief executive of 21 Sports, a sports marketing and

WORLD CUP, Page A9



PHOTO ILLUSTRATION BY LUIS G. RENDON/GLOBE STAFF; PHOTOS: RYAN PIERSE, FRANCESCO PECORARO, JULIAN FINNEY, AND JACK THOMAS/GETTY IMAGES, AURELIEN MORISSARD AND ANDREW MEDICHINI/AP

MORE WORLD CUP COVERAGE

First matches at Gillette

Saturday, June 13: Haiti vs. Scotland — 9 p.m.
Tuesday, June 16: Iraq vs. Norway — 6 p.m.
Friday, June 19: Scotland vs. Morocco — 6 p.m.

Hotels far from full

Despite initial expectations, reservations are weak and prices have dropped. There are many reasons. **D1.**

Immigration issues

Some players and team staff are being questioned or outright barred from entering the United States. **A2.**

Will it be worth it?

No one in cynical Boston has any idea exactly how this mega-event is going to go, writes Dan Shaughnessy. **C1.**

Another beatdown

Thursday: Hot again. High 86-91. Low 70-75.
Friday: Cooler but humid. High 79-84. Low 60-65.
Sunrise: 5:07 Sunset: 8:21
Weather and Comics, D5-6.

Bill Gates told a congressional committee that Jeffrey Epstein exploited information about his extramarital affairs "to pressure me to reengage with him." **A6.**

Wellesley has sued the state to try to block a plan to develop 180 apartments on a parking lot that is owned by MassBay Community College. **D1.**

The Red Sox' slide continued in a 7-5 loss to the Rays, and there's little reason to think the team can turn things around, writes Alex Speier. **C1.**

US, Canada turn page and restore border link

By Paul Heintz
GLOBE STAFF

STANSTEAD, Québec — Sylvie Boudreau was filled with dread when, in January 2025, then-secretary of Homeland Security Kristi Noem came to this quiet corner of the US border and made a modest library a target of the Trump administration's antagonistic approach to Canada.

Built literally atop the border in Derby Line, Vt., and

Stanhope, Québec, the Haskell Free Library & Opera House had a longstanding arrangement that allowed its Canadian patrons to enter from the US side and browse the stacks without first going through customs.

And in short order, Noem put a stop to that, and in the process made this little library an international sensation.

Noem is now out of the job, **LIBRARY, Page A8**



PAUL HEINTZ/GLOBE STAFF

Sylvie Boudreau (center) and Stanstead Mayor Jody Stone cut the ribbon on the new Canadian entrance to the library.

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